Protecting Soft Targets
in an Age of Complex Threats

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CTPN
COUNTER TERRORISM
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Introduction

Increasingly Complex Threat Landscape



> “The threat from terrorism and hostile states presents ‘the most complex and interconnected threat environment we have ever seen.’”

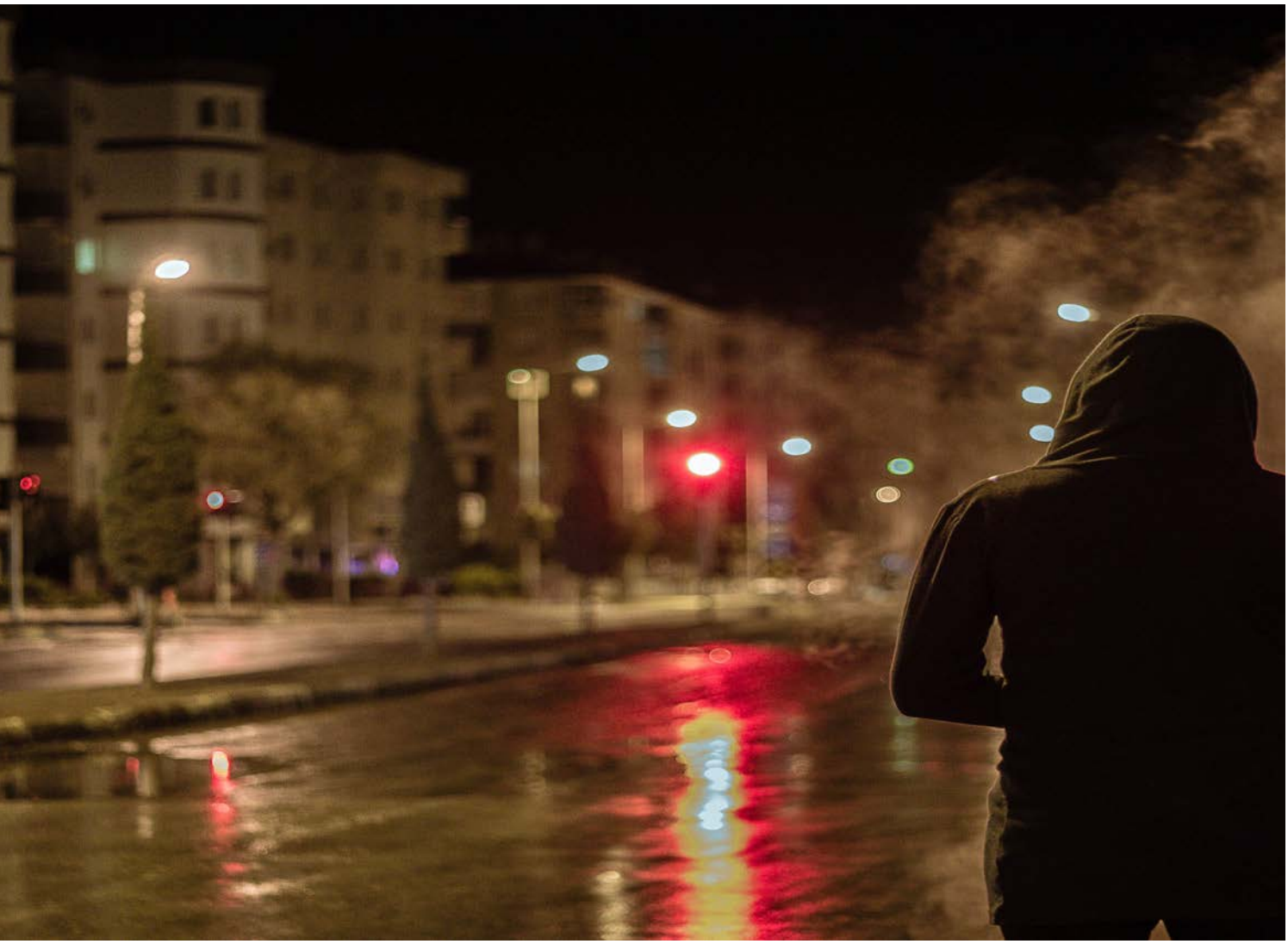
The threat from terrorism and hostile states presents “the most complex and interconnected threat environment we have ever seen” said MI5 Director General Sir Ken McCallum.[1] The aggregate scale of the terrorist threat remains huge, and state threats are worsening.

The geopolitical climate, and global conflict have direct impacts domestically. Hostile states have descended into ugly methods and attempts to commission surveillance, sabotage, arson, or physical violence, as well as espionage.[2] Meanwhile, the ripples from conflict are “filtered through the lens of online media and mixed with existing views and grievances in unpredictable ways.”[3]

This is illustrated by the 2023 knife attack in Hartlepool, United Kingdom (UK), where a man inspired by the Israel-Hamas conflict killed one person and harmed another.[4]

The Hamas terrorist attack of 7th October 2023, and the military response by Israel, escalated tensions and calls for violence against Israeli and Jewish targets from al-Qaeda (AQ) and the Islamic State (IS). Theories of white supremacy and anti-Semitism also spurred across the extreme right-wing.[5] The threat from the extreme right-wing is significant, but Islamist terrorism remains the primary concern.[6]

At the same time, left-wing and anarchist terrorism are becoming more prevalent, as outlined in the



EUROPOL Terrorism Situation and Trend Report of 2025.[7] The left-wing and anarchist spheres across the European Union have reignited long-standing anti-Israel sentiments, reviving violent propaganda characterised by racism and xenophobia.

> **Shifts continue, not only where and how terrorism is felt, but at the very core of what it is.**

Terrorism is no longer confined to organised groups or networks; rather it increasingly emerges from individuals who exploit accessible tools and public spaces to cause harm and disruption. These individuals are less predictable and harder to identify. They challenge traditional counter terrorism models and do not fit the labels of Islamist, right-wing extremist, or anarchist.[8]

"We're [also] encountering more volatile would-be terrorists with only a tenuous grasp of the ideologies they profess to follow. People [who are] viewing both extreme right wing and Islamist extremist instructional material, along with other bits of online hatred, conspiracy theories and disinformation," reported MI5 Director General McCallum.[9]

These people, referred to here as Non-Ideologically Motivated Violent (NIMV) extremists, may have mixed, unstable, or unclear views, shift between ideologies, or lack a comprehensible ideology altogether.[10] They may otherwise have an obsessive, pathological preoccupation with a person or cause, leading to potentially harmful, intrusive, or aggressive behaviors. This can involve fantasy or preparation for mass violence and is often linked to mental health.[11]

Individuals interested in conducting NIMV attacks have been linked with the philosophy of Nihilism. This asserts life, values, and knowledge as inherently meaningless, thus rejecting objective purpose, morality, and truth. Research identified the True Crime Community and the pseudo-Satanic No Lives Matter online groups as the "two most prominent contemporary subcultures of nihilistic violence."[12] The online space has proved to be a threat enabler in this regard.

Online Enabled Extremism

The online space should be considered a serious security priority and one of, if not the largest, security challenges faced today. "Terrorism breeds in squalid corners of the internet where poisonous ideologies, of whatever sort, meet volatile, often chaotic individual lives."[13] There is a blur of motivations, making it hard to decipher if an incident or attack is terrorist or state-directed, or non-ideological, driven by a unique personal grievance, fixation, or mental disturbance.

Psychological vulnerabilities, social isolation, and digital dependency together underpin a significant increase in young people engaging with online extremism, thus driving radicalisation.[14,15] This is further capitalised upon by individuals that perpetuate hate, prey on, or groom others (especially those that may be naïve, impressionable, vulnerable, or unsuspecting) and exploit online rabbit holes including social media, malicious platforms, and deepfakes.

For example, levels of right-wing violent extremists engaging with online occultist and satanic communities have reached record highs.[16] Known as "764" or "Com" networks, these interconnected groups of individuals "compete to share the most violent content, either perpetrated by themselves or by their recruits. The members of these groups specifically target vulnerable minors… into performing acts of self-harm, violence against their circle (i.e., family and friends) and/or even against unknown victims."[17]

This fusion of digital and physical lives has created a pathway from online radicalisation to real-world violence. Online communities desensitise their radicalised members to harm and suffering and slowly draw them in to "visualising, exchanging, and perpetrating violent acts."[18]

In addition, the dark web also hosts proxy and criminal groups capable of coordinating underground activities and conducting malicious acts. This nods to the ever-present principle of crime-as-a-service, which transcends borders and poses unprecedented challenges. The principle reads that if someone does not know how, or have the capability, to do something; another will for a fee. This option applies to all malicious actors including both terrorists and NIMV extremists.

Crime-as-a-service is more likely to be employed by hostile states that target vulnerable individuals or low-level criminals online as proxies. They offer payment in cryptocurrency and instruct them using encrypted apps, before using distance from the act as deniability. [19, 20,] However, this approach can still be exploited by terrorists or NIMV extremists.

The United Nations report '*Beneath the Surface: Terrorist and Violent Extremist use of the Dark Web and Cybercrime-as-a-Service for Cyber-Attacks*' highlighted that the "potential for terrorists and their supporters to leverage… the dark web and capitalise on cybercrime-as-a-service is clear."[21] This is supported by United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres who "flagged trends and developments in social media and the dark web to coordinate attacks, spread propaganda and recruit new followers."[22]

Mis-and-disinformation also plays a significant role in terrorist propaganda and recruitment, as well as in foreign interference and destabilisation from hostile states. It can serve as a significant driver for radicalisation and NIMV, which is accelerated by the ease, speed, and reach with which it can be pushed across borders. The CTPN report on '*Mis–and Disinformation: Extremism in the Digital Age'* discussed this further.[23] Tackling and countering malicious online activity, networks, and extremist materials that misinform, inspire, and incite violence must be a high priority.

The online space should be considered a serious security priority and one of, if not the largest, security challenges faced today.





Terrorism and Non-Ideologically Motivated Violence

Whilst there are no internationally agreed definitions of terrorism or NIMV extremists, the earlier explanations apply. Terrorism is the use or threat of serious violence against a person or serious damage to property where that action is designed to influence the government, intimidate the public, and advance a political, religious, racial, or ideological cause.[24]

In contrast, a NIMV extremist may believe that an injustice has occurred which validates their growing feelings of outrage and desperation, as well as any violent act that follows.[25] This could be an inconvnience such as a declined credit card or a perceived suffering like experiencing rejection, loneliness, or isolation.[26,27]

The key difference between the two is that terrorism is ideologically based whilst NIMV often stems from grievances, fixation, or inspiration without a specific ideology. Whilst the violence, impacts, and consequences of a NIMV attack may be similar to terrorism, the drivers and basis behind the act itself differ. They are distinct in motive and, therefore, management.

This distinction matters as it has a direct impact legally, operationally, and in relation to public communications. It also offers the frame and rationale for decision-makers to assess an attack and decide on its classification.

The 2024 Southport stabbings in the UK, for example, were not declared as terrorism but were described by the judge for the case as “equivalent in its seriousness to terrorist murders”.[28] There was much debate and controversy on whether the definition of terrorism should be broadened or tightened, as well as how these acts of violence are handled.

In response, Jonathan Hall KC, serving as an Independent Reviewer of Terrorism Legislation, conducted a thorough review of the terrorism framework. He concluded that the legal definition of terrorism was wide enough and should not be changed further.[29]

It is not for this report to debate what is classified as terrorism or not. What is evident, however, is that the threat landscape has shifted significantly with NIMV attacks increasing in the United States (US), as well as the UK and Sweden. For this reason, this report will uniquely consider implications for preparedness and the protection of soft targets (as defined in the next section) from the angle of both terrorists and NIMV extremists combined.

It will navigate several short case studies to understand attack situations; analyse the tactics and techniques used by the attackers; review practices in response; consider implications for protection and preparedness; and conclude with recommendations for city authorities. Indeed, this report stresses a need to commit to a broader approach in terms of how societies are protected against, and how agencies prepare to respond to, the expanding threat picture.

Understanding Vulnerable Targets

Defining Hard and Soft Targets

The United Nations Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, Eighth Review, expressed concern over terrorist attacks against vulnerable targets and called upon Member States to strengthen efforts to improve the security and protection of both hard and soft targets.[30]

A 'hard' target encompasses a space that is constantly protected by physical security.[31] It could be critical infrastructure, or a site often frequented by high-profile individuals (such as diplomatic premises), thus requiring an elevated security footprint and available resources.[32] In contrast, 'soft' targets are public, easily accessible, spaces that may be more susceptible to attacks.

Soft targets do not have an internationally agreed upon definition. However, they are widely recognised as being influenced by a combination of factors including low levels of existing security measures; high public accessibility; the symbolic value of the location and those present; the number of potential attack opportunities; as well as the level of local threat awareness.[33,34]

Soft targets vary in size, physical features, permanence, and location, although they are often in urban environments.[35,36] From crowded spaces and hospitality or entertainment districts to educational facilities and public transportation, these locations are defined by their openness, inclusivity, and social value – the very qualities that render them vulnerable. Additional examples include shopping malls, theatres or cinemas, religious sites, and pedestrian areas.[37]

> **"Soft targets are public, easily accessible, spaces that may be more susceptible to attacks."**



Prioritising Soft Targets

Terrorist groups actively encourage their followers to pursue attacks against soft targets.[38] Ideological and extremist publications provide tactical advice and can specify attack locations. For example, an online magazine posted by the Islamic State (IS) urged sympathisers to target "large outdoor conventions and celebrations, pedestrian-congested streets, outdoor markets, festivals, parades and political rallies."[39] Such publications are intended to attract new supporters, encourage radicalised individuals, identify targets, and provide instructions for using weapons.[40] An increase in attacks on people in public spaces has been identified.[41]

In similar ways, soft targets are being noticed by NIMV extremists. Given the large and accessible crowds that can frequent such locations, they may be particularly attractive to those aiming to commit attacks and receive media coverage without extensive planning or resources.[42] Sadly, it was NIMV groups that were connected to at least four school shooters, five disrupted school shooting plots, and two Swedish stabbing sprees in 2024 alone."[43]

Indeed, soft target selection must also be considered through the lens of notoriety. A report by the Federal Bureau of Investigation, '*Making Prevention a Reality*,' discussed notoriety as a motivational driver for attackers. Attackers can seek to be more notorious than the last one and, unfortunately, body count and type of victim can factor into the notoriety the attacker receives. Horrifically, the 2011 Norway attacks had the largest death toll at 77.[44]

A core challenge arises in increasing security without compromising the open nature of any site, especially given that soft targets are likely to have financial constraints or limited budgets dedicated to security training, resources and personnel, or physical installations.[45,46] Equally challenging is garnering support to secure sites that have not been prioritised previously or may be relatively open and vulnerable by nature, such as streets or temporary event areas.



Private owners or organisers of sites, along with local or central government, are responsible for meeting security needs and reducing vulnerabilities.[47] However, in practice, there can be a lack of clarity over who is responsible for protecting grey space. This is the external zone that transitions between any given site, where there is a degree of protection, to another. This could include a venue's immediate perimeter, the surrounding streets, car parks, or transport links.

A broad range of useful materials are already available. These include, but are not limited to the CTPN report on *'Protecting Major Events and Crowded Places'*, the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism report on '*The Protection of Vulnerable Targets and Major Sporting Events*'[48,49]; the UK National Protective Security Authority resources on protecting major events, ingress and egress; public premises, and hostile vehicle mitigation[50,51,52,53]; as well as the US Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency guidance on securing public gatherings and school safety.[54,55]

Despite existing resources, there are many examples of attacks against soft targets. There remains a clear need to focus on protecting and preparing soft targets in a way that ensures they remain accessible and inviting, yet secure.

The forthcoming analysis is framed through six case studies which vary in attack type, motivation, recency, and location. These are taken from the US, UK, and Sweden. Each took place at one of two soft targets: street and public festivals or educational facilities.

2025 New Year's Vehicle Ramming Attack, New Orleans



On New Year's Day 2025, a 42-year-old man drove a rented truck containing an ISIS flag through a crowd in New Orleans, Louisiana's historic French Quarter.[56,57] Individuals attending the night's festivities sought refuge in nearby clubs and restaurants. The vehicle ramming attack, which lasted for almost three blocks, left 14 dead and 30 injured.[58,59] It ended abruptly when the attacker crashed into construction equipment, opened fire on police, and died in the shootout.[60]

The attack took place on Bourbon Street, a densely populated corridor known for its nightlife and lined with restaurants and bars, which was flooded with pedestrians celebrating the New Year. Vehicle bollards which would typically block the area were undergoing maintenance, but local police had parked a car to block oncoming traffic from entering the the street in preparation for the anticipated size of the crowd.[61,62]

Unfortunately, the attacker was able to bypass the parked car by driving onto the sidewalk, hitting pedestrians and festival goers as it accelerated.[63]

The attacker was a Texas-born US citizen.[64] He had been divorced twice and had a restraining order against him throughout the second divorce case for threats and physical harm.[65] In addition to financial difficulties, resulting from a mortgage payment and failing businesses, he'd had several encounters with law enforcement resulting in charges.[66]

Hours before driving from Texas to New Orleans to conduct the attack, the attacker posted five videos to social media.[67,68] In them, he referenced violence against his family and dreams which inspired his allegiance to ISIS. These are potential motives for the attack, as well as difficulty transitioning to civilian life after serving in the Army for 10 years.[69,70]

Following the attack, Louisiana Governor Jeff Landry declared New Orleans to be in a state of emergency.[71] The attack had raised serious concerns about New Orleans' urban security and infrastructure vulnerabilities, especially as the Collegiate Sugar Bowl match was scheduled for 1st January at the downtown Superdome stadium.

In efforts to clear the city for the upcoming match, New Orleans conducted security sweeps and sourced reinforcements from the Louisiana National Guard. Officials also sought to reassure the public that the city was safe by revisiting and updating the already extensive security plans following the vehicle ramming attack.[72,73,74] After a short delay, the match went ahead.[75]

2019 Gilroy Garlic Festival Shooting, California



The garlic festival was an annual food festival with live-music and family-friendly stands, attracting more than 100,000 attendees over the course of three days. It had operated for 40 years without incident.[76]

On 28th July 2019 at approximately 17:41, this changed. A 19-year-old man cut through the back fence and began shooting randomly at crowds, killing three and injuring 17 others.[77,78] Law enforcement eliminated the threat within one minute.[79]

The attacker had legally purchased an assault-style rifle in Las Vegas, Nevada, although the weapon was illegal to own in California where the attack took place.[80] He had another weapon and ammunition in his vehicle, along with a rifle scope and flashlight. Furthermore, he wore body armor with extra ammunition.[81] Metal detectors and wands were used at the entrance of the event; however, the attacker trespassed at the rear of the perimeter, cutting through the fencing used for the event to avoid detection and work around existing security measures.[82]

Investigators did not identify a particular ideology or motive for the attack. The attacker was said to have explored violent ideologies, including some which directly competed with one another, which is characteristic of grievance-based NIMV extremists.[83]

He also created an Instagram account in the days leading up to the attack and reportedly posted twice; one a photo of the garlic festival and another of a reference to a book that espouses white supremacist material.[84] Amid the chaos, a festival goer asked the attacker why he was doing it, and he responded, “because I’m really angry.” The US Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) later opened a domestic terrorism investigation into the attack.[85]

2017 Route 91 Harvest Festival Attack, Las Vegas



The largest US mass shooting since 1966 took place on 1st October 2017 in Las Vegas, Nevada. A 64-year-old man opened fire from his hotel window at Mandalay Bay onto a nearby concert crowd.[86] The concert was held at an outdoor venue that accommodated over 22,000 attendees and was situated along the famed Las Vegas Strip, which is filled with hotels and casinos.

The attacker killed 59 and injured over 500 people attending the concert.[87] After shots began around 22:00 local time, nearby hotels were locked down as local police searched for the shooter.[88,89]

There was confusion as responders tried to distinguish whether the shots were coming from the festival grounds or elsewhere. Approximately 12 minutes after the first shot, police reached the thirty-second floor of the Mandalay Bay Hotel where they found the body and ammunition of the attacker who had committed suicide.[90] Along with the body, police found 23 firearms in the hotel room, all of which had been purchased legally.[91]

Upon further investigation, the FBI discovered the attacker was looking for other large crowds to carry out attacks on.[92] His internet history showed that he had booked hotel rooms overlooking festivals in Chicago and downtown Las Vegas.[93] The attacker did not have any known terrorist, political, or religious organisation before the shooting. Those close to him knew him as a man who enjoyed gambling, travelling, and investing in property. While in Nevada to conduct the attack, he had spent over 1.5 million US dollars on gambling.[94]

Although the FBI investigation never clearly identified a definitive motive, the attacker had expressed frustration with how casinos treated high-stake players such as himself.[95] Through the investigation, it was also revealed that he started to display abnormal behavior when he became obsessed with guns and distanced himself from his girlfriend and family.[96]

Following the events of the Las Vegas Route 91 Harvest Festival attack, the city revised its approach to public safety measures and large-scale event planning. Hotels in the area increased security measures for guests and staff, and some even installed X-ray machines for baggage screening.[97,98] Given Las Vegas' dependence on tourism and entertainment, the city worked quickly to reassure visitors and residents of their safety.

Educational Facilities



On 4th February 2025, a 35-year-old man killed ten people and then himself at Campus Risbergska school, an adult education centre in Örebro about 125 miles from Stockholm, Sweden.[99,100] The school provided educational classes for adults including language courses, vocational training, and programmes for individuals with intellectual disabilities.[101]

The shooting began on a Tuesday afternoon at 12:33 local time, when many students had already left following morning exams.[102,103] Those remaining on campus fled or sheltered in nearby buildings, barricading themselves inside classrooms.[104] Local schools had been engaging in lockdown drills, which have been credited with preparing the students and teachers to act.[105]

The attacker's motive is believed to be suicide.[106] He was found dead inside the school from a self-inflicted gunshot wound.[107] He had a history of mental illness, was struggling financially, and was known to isolate himself from the community.[108,109] The attacker was from the area and had previously attended Campus Risbergska in 2013, 2019, and 2021.[110,111] Though immigrants and individuals accessing language services were killed, it is believed that the attack was on the school itself, rather than targeting of immigrant communities.[112]

Sweden rarely experiences school shootings, though the country has high levels of gun ownership and crime.[113,114] Gun crime has predominantly been associated with gang violence, and individuals wishing to purchase a gun must first apply for a permit and provide justification to the police as to what it will be used for.[115] However, it is worth noting the Campus Risbergska attacker legally owned four rifles, three of which were found in the school with him. All of the firearms were purchased long before the attack, three of them in 2011.

Campus Risbergska was previously a high school and had an access control system installed. This system was fully functional but no longer being used by 2025 as the campus had transitioned to an open school building.[118] This represents a key challenge for educational facilities: creating an inviting space that fosters learning through positive school culture and environments while also ensuring safety is a core foundational element. The balance here is critical.

Campus Risbergska partially re-opened in late February and fully reopened in August 2025.[119] A total of 20 million SEK was spent to renovate the school's campus after the shooting. Returning students found improved safety measures (locked doors, code access, bag checks, and window curtains) and trained employees to monitor attendees and provide crisis support.[121, 122, 123]

Nationwide, the Swedish government committed 300 million SEK to school security measures, including grants for security cameras and additional check points.[124] There was also a nationwide debate regarding the reporting and documenting of mental illness and the management of gun permits. This related to the obligations and responsibilities of doctors' (and other public officials or institutions) to report different types of mental illness to the police (as the authority responsible for granting permits for guns), and when/how this should be done.

2025 Annunciation Catholic School Shooting, Minnesota



Annunciation Catholic School Shooting in Minneapolis — Chad Davis — CC BY 4.0

Annunciation Catholic School in Minneapolis, Minnesota, hosts students from pre-school through to eighth grade on its campus.[125] It is considered a Christian environment for learning.[126] On 27th August 2025, two children were killed and 21 people were injured (18 children and three adults) when over a hundred gunshots were fired through the school church windows.[127, 128]

The attacker was a 23-year-old former student of the school who was quiet and resentful of both education and religion.[129] Their mother had also worked at the school for five years, covering the front desk and the parish.[130,131] She led a few classes on the intermingling of faith into daily life, a lesson which did not appear to resonate with the attacker.[132]

The attacker legally purchased a rifle, shotgun, and pistol in preparation for the shooting, all of which were found at the scene.[133] The attacker had also visited the church several weeks before the shooting under the guise of reconnecting with the Catholic faith, instead using the opportunity to document the inside of the building.[134] In addition to creating a diagram of the interior, videos showed that the attacker planned to set off smoke canisters in the stairwells and barricade emergency exit doors using two-by-fours.[135]

Victims caught in the attack would have found themselves surrounded by orange smoke and unable to leave.[136]

On the day of the shooting, just before 08:30, the attacker attempted to enter the church as planned but was barred by the church's locked doors.[137] The school had a regular practice of locking the doors once Mass began; an action which has been credited with saving "countless lives" during the attack.[138,139] Unable to enter, the attacker instead fired through the windows of the church where teachers, parents, and nearly two-hundred students were inside attending a service marking the first week of school.[140,141,142,143]

A motive has not been determined, though the attacker had expressed "hate toward almost every group imaginable" said Joseph Thompson, acting US Attorney for the District of Minnesota.[144] The attacker had also praised past mass shootings.[145] The attacker struggled with depression and suicidal thoughts, eventually dying of a self-inflicted gunshot in the Annunciation Catholic Church's car park.[146] Writings found after the shooting plainly showed the attacker fighting with their mental state. "Find me I am begging for help, I am screaming for help" one note read.[147]

In a video, they are also recorded saying "I really just want a place to put my thoughts. I can't talk to a therapist or family because I will immediately be reported."[148]

Mis-and-disinformation after the Annunciation Catholic Church shooting exploited the fact that the attacker's gender identity was unclear, though they legally changed from a male-presenting name to a female-presenting name in 2020.[149,150] Commentary from the extreme right-wing named the attacker as transgender and falsely claimed that transgender individuals were prone to mental illness.[151] The act was "trans-terrorism" claimed a right-wing writer.[152]

John Pachankis, a public health, and psychiatry professor, spoke out against this narrative, stating that "Violence is determined by a multitude of societal problems and personal life circumstances. A school shooter who happens to be transgender has more in common with other school shooters than with other transgender people."[153] Minneapolis Mayor Jacob Frey echoed this, speaking against anyone who sought to use the shooting to "villainise our trans community."[154] The attack is being investigated as an act of "domestic terrorism and a hate crime".[155]

2024 Southport Stabbings, Stockport, United Kingdom



On 29th July 2024, 12 people were stabbed at a Taylor Swift themed dance workshop at a studio in Southport.[156] The sold-out class had been advertised to primary school students, and the victims were mainly children between the ages of six and nine.[157]

The attacker was a 17-year-old male with a disturbing past. In 2019, he had called a helpline to ask, "What should I do if I want to kill someone?"[158] Shortly after, he was expelled after repeatedly bringing a knife to school and later attacking a student with a hockey stick.[159]

His family felt that he "became another person" after the expulsion.[160] They testified to his purchase of a machete in 2023 and the discovery of a bow-and-arrow, as well as the ingredients for ricin poison, in his bedroom in the weeks before the attack.[161]

On the day of the attack, he hailed a taxi to the dance studio and was caught on security camera footage unsuccessfully attempting to enter via a locked door.[162,163] A short time after, the attacker spotted an open entrance and entered wearing a surgical mask and hoodie whilst carrying a 20-centimeter kitchen knife.[164,165] In just 15 minutes, 10 children and two adults were stabbed.[166] Of the 26 children who attended the class, three were murdered, eight were physically injured, and 15 escaped but suffered psychologically.[167]

Adults were also injured while attempting to protect the children from the attacker. Residents of the neighborhood rushed to the scene bearing medical supplies. A witness was working in his office when he heard the screaming and stepped in.[168] While helping a child, he was stabbed by the attacker.[169] One of the teachers, who suffered life-threatening injuries, instructed the children to run and hide in the bathroom as the attacker made his way through.[170]

Following the stabbings, the attacker's identity was initially kept private due to his age, as sharing personal details of children is subject to stricter legal provisions. Simultaneously, rumors and disinformation spread on social media, which suggested that the attacker was a Syrian refugee who had entered the UK illegally.[171] Right-wing groups grasped this narrative, and national protests erupted which targeted immigrants and businesses.[172]

The Southport stabbings were not classified as terrorism because the attack did not further a political, religious, or ideological cause. However, "whether the motivation was terrorism or not misses the point," said the judge presiding over the case. "[The attack] has caused such shock and revulsion… that it must be viewed as being at the extreme level of crime."[173]

In November 2025, the UK experienced a second NIMV attack on a London-bound intercity train. An individual has subsequently been charged with 10 counts of attempted murder using a knife. Although it initially triggered a counter terrorism response, it rapidly emerged that this was not a terrorist incident. Like Southport, however, a counter terrorism style response was necessary.

Summary of Case Studies

The Annunciation Catholic Church shooting, Gilroy Garlic Festival shooting, and New Orleans New Years vehicle ramming are under investigation as acts of terrorism. Each of the attackers are suspected to have followed a specific terrorist group or a related cause.

The Annunciation shooting targeted children via a firearm through a window. The Gilroy Garlic Festival attacker also purchased a firearm. The New Orleans attacker otherwise utilised a rented Ford F-150 Lightning vehicle via an app.[174] This is an electric pickup truck that boasts of a heavy weight, silent operation, and rapid acceleration, all elements which likely contributed to the effectiveness of the attack.[175] The choice to rent the vehicle via an app also made it more difficult for authorities to track and identify the driver.

In contrast, the Örebro School attack in Sweden also used firearms but was not declared as terrorism.[176,177] Nor was the Las Vegas Harvest Festival attack, where the perpetrator was also heavily armed. Almost 50 guns were found of varying types, and 12 of them had been outfitted with bump stocks, allowing the semi-automatic weapons to fire as though they were fully automatic.[178] Modifying semi-automatic guns can be an affordable way to get a similar result.[179] It is worth noting that extremists with weapons already present in the home increases the likelihood that that they will be used for an attack.[180]

The Southport stabbings were not classified as terrorism either but are known for their sheer brutality; committed by hand and at staggering numbers.[181,182,183] Notably, the Southport attacker was easily able to acquire weapons. Using a false name, age, and encrypted software, he successfully purchased knives, a crossbow, and a machete online from Amazon's delivery service.[184] This included the 20-centimeter kitchen knife which was used in the attack.[185]

Regardless of the weapon of choice, terrorists and NIMV attackers often have violent backgrounds. The New Orleans and Southport attackers had histories of violence and encounters with law enforcement. Nearly all the case studies presented also identified struggles with mental illness – including social isolation, depression, and suicide. The perpetrators had difficulties fitting in with their peers and felt personally grieved by society, which manifested as anger and obsession toward their perceived aggressor.

"Simple attack methods, which require minimal planning, are favored for low barriers and ease of access. These include firearms, blunt and bladed weapons, vehicle ramming, and arson."



Notable Trends and Trajectories

Terrorists, and NIMV extremists, aim to remain undetected until operational, using simple plots (often inspired and informed online and via the dark web). Simple attack methods, which require minimal planning, are favored for low barriers and ease of access. These include firearms, blunt and bladed weapons, vehicle ramming, and arson. Arson can encompass improvised incendiary devices (IIDs), such as Molotov cocktails or gasoline tanks. Although these attack types have varied lethality, they have been frequently utilised.

Nearly 20% of the mass attacks in public spaces studied by the US Secret Service National Threat Assessment Centre involved the use of a bladed weapon.[186] Worryingly, knife crime in England also increased by 57% between 2014 and 2024, the year of the Southport attack.[187] Bladed weapons offer a smaller number of observable indicators during pre-planning and a shorter window of time for detection and disruption.[188] Despite this, thankfully mass stabbings are rare. Other instruments like machetes, hatches, or box cutters, or even scissors, screwdrivers, or shards of glass may be used instead.[189, 190] Similarly, blunt force weapons, such as hammers, follow the same lines of accessibility and concealment.[191]

A combination of simple attack types, both primary and secondary methods, may also be used. For example, past attacks evidence how vehicle ramming may precede the use of a firearm or bladed weapon to increase lethality. There are multiple cases. On 2nd October 2025, a vehicle was driven into a crowd before others were stabbed at a synagogue just north of Manchester, UK. The attack killed two and left four injured.[192] The New Orleans attacker also targeted law enforcement with a firearm after his vehicle stalled.

It is worth noting, however, that from 2006 to 2014, 82 individuals were injured or killed from vehicle ramming attacks.[193] This number rose to over 600 people in 2016 alone. This is significant as a trend and trajectory, in addition to bladed weapons. Many attackers use their own or a family vehicle, while others steal or rent. If rented, they often prefer to select larger vehicles.[194] Acquisition of both vehicles and bladed weapons is far easier than other modes of attack. They also require zero to minimal planning and training, which increases the likelihood.[195]

In terms of trends and trajectories, it is also important to stress the link between misogyny, NIMV extremism, and terrorism. Whilst there are multiple drivers, contributing factors, and pathways towards extremism, many terrorist ideologies are inherently misogynistic.[196] This also translates across to incels and NIMV extremists where grievances become the fault of another group – such as women. This can result in oppression, degradation, and dehumanisation in a bid to justify the failings and subsequent actions of the extremist. This is accelerated by the online space which, as covered earlier, is pushing record numbers of malicious, extremist, and satanic content.

The gateway from personal failings to misogyny, extremism, and terrorism has been evidenced in various attacks including the 2016 Nice attack, 2016 Pulse Nightclub shooting, and 2017 Westminster Bridge attack.[197] Dr Sajjan Gohels' paper, *'The Misogyny Trap: Understanding the Motivations Behind the New Orleans Terrorist Attack,'* provides a case in point that deserves further attention. The weaponisation of gender is a severe problem with huge implications.



> “The evolving, blurred, and expanding threat landscape faced is broader, more complex, and more interconnected than ever before. It follows that any whole-system approach must mirror this to counter it.”

A Whole-System Approach

The concept of a whole-system approach is not new. It is a collaborative, integrated strategy focused on tackling complex problems. The need for this remains widely recognised in countering violent extremism and terrorism and is increasingly urgent. The challenge, of course, is achieving successful implementation against the evolving threat picture. This requires carefully crafted, proactive, and sustained approaches backed by investment and resources.

It demands approaches that span the online space to youth engagement and socio-economic development; violence prevention and intervention; all the way to protection, preparedness, and response, as well as everything in between. It is inherently sensitive and political.

The case studies presented previously demonstrated that no two attacks are the same. Yet, they also demonstrated similarities between those that are conducted by NIMV extremists or classified as terrorism. Regardless of classification, the evolving, blurred, and expanding threat landscape faced is broader, more complex, and more interconnected than ever before. It follows that any whole-system approach must mirror this to counter it. Likewise, a multidisciplinary lens that integrates intelligence, behavioural science and psychology, security, emergency management, and public health, among others, is necessary.

The UK Counter Terrorism Strategy, CONTEST, is founded on the pillars of Prevent, Pursue, Protect, and Prepare; Sweden uses the terms Prevent, Avert, Protect, and Manage.[198,199] The US counterintelligence strategy similarly uses Deter, Detect, Disrupt, and Defend.[200] Regardless of country-specific terminology, this evidences a common strategic approach that is broadly transferrable. This report, however, follows the UK CONTEST strategy where the aim of Protect is to strengthen protection against a terrorist attack, and the aim of Prepare is to minimise the impact and likelihood of attacks. This is about building proportionate security measures and responses to a range of attack methodologies, wherever they occur.

Protect and Prepare must be treated as mutually dependent, and these areas are the focus and remit of this report. They are complementary to, but distinct from, Prevent and Pursue which otherwise make what is referred to as the ‘4Ps’. However, Prevent and Pursue must be recognised; they form extensive expert fields and, given mental and public health fall under prevention, excluding them from this report would result in an incomplete reflection. Therefore, given the overlap and commonalities between NIMV extremist and terrorist attacks on soft targets, it is important to first acknowledge the role of Prevent in this regard.

> **There is no single pathway to extremism and violence. Rather, a complex set of factors apply ranging from mental health to social-economic deprivation, life experience and grievances to isolation and loneliness.**



Recognising the Role of Prevent

Prevention focuses on actions which aim to stop an attack from occurring in the first place.[201] These measures are intended to be long-term and holistic, focused on the root causes of an issue for at-risk individuals.[202] It is important to remember, however, that there is no single pathway to extremism and violence. Rather, a complex set of factors apply ranging from mental health to social-economic deprivation, life experiences and grievances to isolation and loneliness.

Risk factors which influence a person's decision to engage in violence occur across multiple levels.[203,204] At the individual level, it could be the person's education, employment and income, housing security, or history of substance abuse or trauma.[205] At the family and peer level, the people around the individual determine whether relationships are healthy and if they have positive connections.[206]

Peer pressure can also play a role, both positive and negative.

A person's environment will affect their decision as well. Community level factors focus on the areas where social relationships occur.[207] These can include a neighborhood's poverty level, population density, level of cohesion among its residents, and the existence of residential segregation.[208,209] This is non-exhaustive; the list goes on.

Risk factors are characteristics which can lead to negative outcomes.[210] Protective factors, in contrast, reduce the chances of a negative outcome and can counter the effect of a risk factor.[211] Some risk and protective factors are unchanging while others will vary over time.[212,213] Ultimately, people need stability; a life that is worth living and worth protecting.

This is why building the disciplines of public health, psychology, behavioural and social sciences into counter extremism and counter terrorism is so important in progressing approaches.

Research suggests that the early identification, intervention, and treatment of mental health conditions can have a significant effect on violence prevention.[214,215] Vulnerable individuals who are equipped with proper mental health support services are less likely to internalise their emotions to potentially dangerous levels or seek out niche beliefs in search of belonging. Indeed, researchers have found that people in close contact with potentially violent individuals are more likely to look for mental health and community support than to law enforcement.[216]

The public health approach is a four-step process: (1) define and monitor the problem; (2) identify the risk, protective factors and the affected population; (3) design, implement, and evaluate interventions; and (4) implement interventions and scale up effective policies.[217,218] This approach, outlined by the World Health Organisation, seeks to address the underlying risk factors which increase the likelihood of an individual becoming violent.[219,220]

Violence intervention programmes, sometimes referred to as community violence interventions, are other initiatives that target cycles of violence.[221,222] These programs engage high-risk individuals and groups and connect them to social services which encourage relationship building and provide new opportunities.[223,224] Safe Streets, a violence intervention program in Baltimore, Maryland reduced homicides and nonfatal shootings by 16-23% between 2007 and 2022.[225] Similar programs in New York City experienced declining gun violence rates and, importantly, found that community members were less supportive of the use of violence for resolving disputes.[226] These strategies serve as inspiration for further city-level initiatives.

This is where public health and violence prevention initiatives intersect with the field of urban planning by integrating various disciplines into the design of city spaces.[227] They seek to ensure that cities function not only as places to live, but also as areas where people can find belonging and growth. Changes which account for this built environment have shown to reduce community level risk factors and can also encourage and foster safe and secure areas.[228]

These approaches align with the US Department of Homeland Security's '*Strategic Framework for Countering Terrorism and Targeted Violence*,' which emphasises collaboration between the government, private sector, and civil society to prevent radicalisation.[229]

Protective Security in Cities

Terrorists and NIMV extremists' probe for gaps in protective security, preparedness, and response capabilities. It follows that public authorities must always monitor the threat. As soon as it starts to change, it is important to look at the patterns and map probable trajectories; utilising trends, knowledge, and experiences to understand what could, and what is likely to, happen. This informs real-time operations, prevention, preparedness, and protective security.

The concept of security by design is widely recognised and used to strengthen new building sites or retrofits, city-centre areas, or other vulnerable locations, for example. Materials such as, *'Security by Design: Protection of Public Spaces from Terrorist Attacks'*[230]; '*Integrating Security-by-Design into Sustainable Urban Planning for Safer, More Accessible, and Livable Public Spaces'*[231]; and '*Measuring and Improving the Resilience of Outdoor Open Areas Against Terrorist Acts: A Behavioural Design Approach'*[232] offer further detail.

The principle incorporates layered protective security, a standard approach taken to protect people and the environments they inhabit.[233,234] It is based on the knowledge that no single security measure can protect against all threats. Instead, defence measures are layered and combined so that the further a threat might progress, the more obstacles it faces.[235]

Layered protective security protects an internal element – a person, location, or building – and adds protective strategies moving outward. The aim is that layered systems will continue to perform even if one element of security fails or is overcome.

There are many successful examples of security by design and layered physical security measures relating to sports stadia, for example. Established static sites that benefit from investment and tried and tested security measures can fare well.

> **Layered protective security protects an internal element - a person, location, or building - and adds protective strategies moving outward.**

However, pop-up sites like fan-zones or markets, open footprint events such as marathons, or other publicly accessible locations pose challenges.

New Orleans developed a layered protective security approach against vehicle ramming following the 2016 Nice and Berlin attacks. Specifically surrounding the popular Bourbon Street, three levels of security measures were enacted: barricades, bollards, and heavy sanitation trucks.[236] Unfortunately, at the time of the 2025 New Years attack, the bollards were undergoing upgrades ahead of the Super Bowl match and were not functioning properly.[237,238,239] The temporary parked cars intended as coverage for this were inadequate, resulting in incomplete layered security and a gap that the attacker was able to exploit.

It is not possible to protect everywhere all the time, but layered protective security continues to be a primary method. As noted earlier, there is already a significant amount of protective security resources and guidance available which this report will not repeat. However, based on the presence of NIMV attacks in addition to the persistent threat of terrorism, there is a need to think more holistically about protective security in the modern day.

This leans towards intensifying approaches to protect soft targets – such as open event footprints, education establishments, places of worship, and public transportation – by ensuring increased investment and a programmatic approach to build security and resilience. It highlights the need for community engagement, youth awareness, and broader public communications.

Security minded communications have proven beneficial. Examples include *'See It, Say It, Sort It'* and *'Run, Hide, Tell'*, as well as initiatives like *'See, Check, and Notify (SCaN)'*, and Project Servator.[240,241] The UK National Protective Security Authority offers further resources on denying, deterring, detecting, and disrupting hostile reconnaissance, as well as amplifying physical security measures, whilst simultaneously seeking to improve customer care.[242,243] Their Protective Security Risk Management Process is



Opportunities are also presented by technology and artificial intelligence (AI) to help enhance protective security and operations. The CTPN report on *'Artificial Intelligence: Securing Our Future'* discusses these threats and opportunities further.[245] It includes reference to the NATO DEXTER (detection of explosives and firearms to counter terrorism) project; a flagship initiative of the NATO Science for Peace and Security Programme. Using AI-enabled technologies, it works to identify firearms and explosives among moving pedestrians, remotely and in real-time.[246]

There is the potential to harness AI anomaly detection and security systems in support of soft targets. Likewise, in principle, the systems could be trained to assist in the identification of hostile behaviour. Behavioural sciences are not only important in identifying hostile behaviour, but also to understand public behaviour to inform protective security in the context of soft targets.

Take the PEARL initiative, for example. PEARL (Person-Environment-Activity Research Laboratory) is located at University College London and enables the detailed research of how people interact with their environment. It is a multisensory facility in which any given physical environment (such as train or classroom) can be reconstructed inside the building as required.[247]

This can enable the analysis of people's responses against various scenarios by using a range of sensors. These include tracking of eyes and neurological processes, electrodermal activity sensors, heart-rate monitors, oxygen-use monitors, and physical motion.[248,249]

The findings of a tailored exercise or simulated research project could subsequently inform the design of urban spaces, buildings, or transport systems that could be soft targets. Simple steps like examining the difference in security, evacuation, or response effectiveness, if a building is configured differently, could support Protect and Prepare strategies. It could also inform the decision-making and responses of emergency services to a NIMV or terrorist attack. This directly complements the important work already being undertaken by protective security authorities and emergency services but is a tool to be harnessed.

Innovative approaches towards security need to be a core element of city development strategies by combining multiple disciplines, considering the integration of technology, and thinking beyond security by design to explore more ways to reduce the threat and impact of violence. National and regional prioritisation, sustained investment, and resourcing, as well as public-private partnerships, are critical to mobilise change and accelerate progress.

Multi-Agency Preparedness

“
At single and multi- agency levels, clear structures and arrangements for situational awareness, coordination, and communication are also critical for preparedness, intelligence, and response.
”

A useful way to understand the risk of terrorism or NIMV extremism is to consider it as “the product of vulnerability (how susceptible a place or system is to attack), threat (likelihood and modes of attack), and criticality (how serious the consequences could be).”[250] This statement offers a guide when identifying and prioritising soft targets.

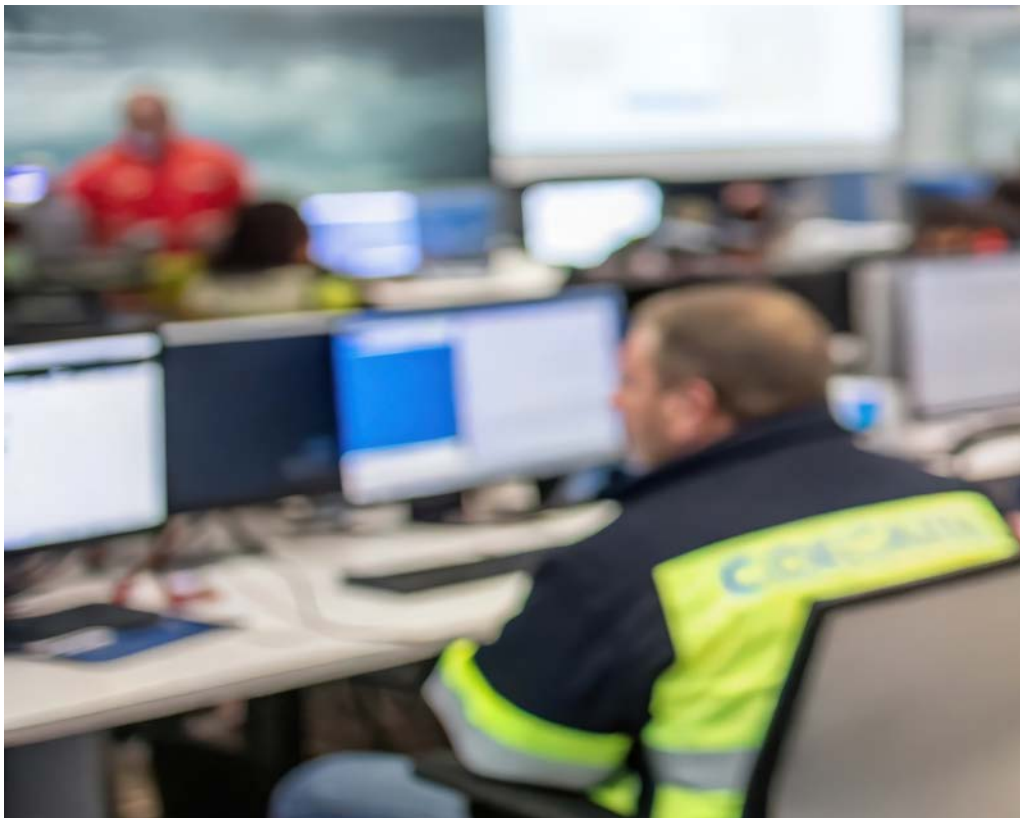
The prioritisation of soft targets is challenging. Ideally, they all need to be prioritised. Yet, some may demand more attention than others. The nature of accessible but enclosed environments such as trains and buses, shops-restaurants-cinemas, or educational facilities can make it harder for people to disperse. There is much that could be done in terms of protective security but also in terms of multi-agency preparedness.

Given the evolving threat picture discussed at the start of this report and the ever-present challenge of NIMV extremists, in addition to terrorism, there is need to consider any implications this may have for single and multi-agency plans, policies, procedures, and operational capabilities.

Preparedness is a continuous cycle of planning, training, exercising, and evaluating.[251] This cycle challenges levels of readiness and tests whether key steps take place as intended. For example, a hurricane-prone city may plan for residents to evacuate using contracted buses coming from nearby areas. However, a functional or full-scale exercise could find that a late-notice hurricane would not allow enough time for the contracted vehicles to be staffed, arrive, and evacuate residents before the storm hits. Once the gap has been identified through exercise evaluation, the plans and training would be updated. The updates would then be exercised and evaluated again in a repetitive cycle of continuous improvement.

It is good practice to engage the full range of stakeholders in the development of security and emergency plans and, in the case of soft targets, consider mechanisms to exchange information and cooperate with private sector partners using legal, regulatory, and informal means.

This approach should be applied across soft targets, especially accessible but enclosed environments. Active shooter drills,



often referred to as lockdown drills, offer a key example of training and exercising in action within the soft target space. Used frequently in the US, the exact nature of these drills varies by school, but most have students and teachers practicing how to lock classroom doors, cover windows, avoid lines of sight, and remain quiet. More intense versions will instruct them on how to build furniture barriers and defend themselves using classroom objects. These are widely viewed as a success and a crucial element in preparing schools for attacks in the modern world and could be applied to other locations.

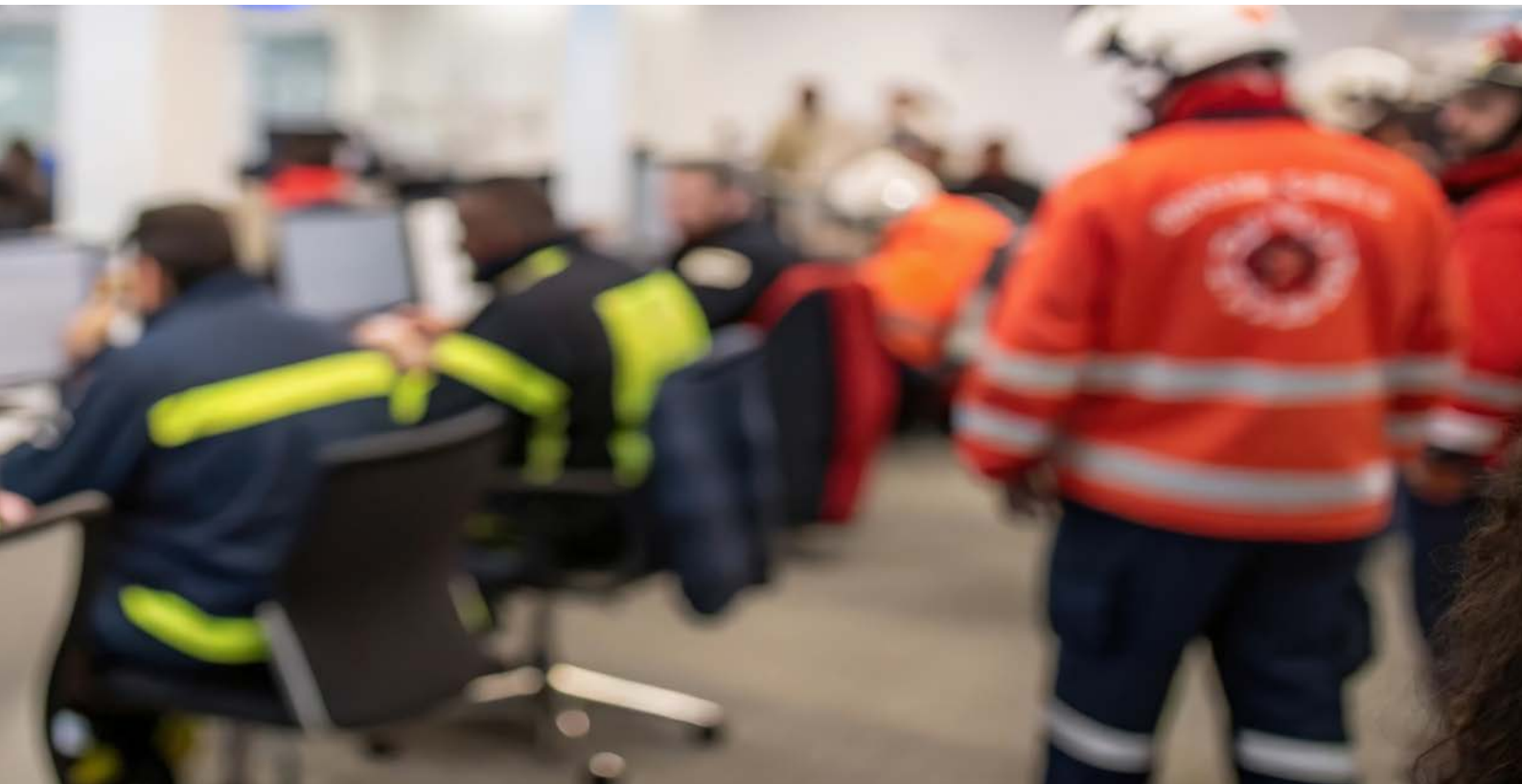
However, lockdown drills are not perfect. Every child and teenager is different. A 2020 study of youths aged 14-24 in the US found that 56.1% of the students felt more prepared for an active shooter event.[252] 60.2% also reported feeling "unsafe, scared, helpless, or sad" as a result of the drills.[253] In rare cases, students have not wanted to return to school or left wondering if they were "going to finish the day alive."[254] This is an important consideration when preparing for attacks; it can be intense, and not all measures will be appropriate for all individuals.

The same principle applies for train operators and other transport staff, as well as those in the hospitality and entertainment industries. The UK Terrorism Protection of Premises Act 2025 relies on procedures such as lockdown, invacuation, or evacuation, and how these are trained, communicated, and responsibly owned. Other initiatives like advanced first aid to security control or incident command training programmes are equally important.[255]

At single and multi-agency levels, clear structures and arrangements for situational awareness, coordination, and communication are also critical for preparedness, intelligence, and response. This ranges from operational protocols and procedures to strategic capability-based frameworks. The CTPN report on '*Strategic Coordination'* covers these areas.[256]

The establishment of fully functioning Fixated Threat Assessment Centres (FTAC) is otherwise pertinent. These are collaborative models where law enforcement and mental health professionals co-locate and work together to identify, assess, triage, and intervene against at-risk individuals.[257,258,259] They seek to address the underlying factors which can later manifest as concerning violent behaviors.[260] FTACs circle back into the Prevent space, but the work is directly relevant to posture in Protect and Prepare. It is a critical approach that warrants sustained investment and should work in synergy with fusion centers – that otherwise gather, analyse, and share threat-related information – within the wider intelligence and investigative cycle.

The number of elements that need to connect and deliver to achieve preparedness emphasises the need for interactive tabletop and live exercises that seek to assess all relevant plans and capabilities, coordination structures, and information cells. A comprehensive training and exercise programme, based on common NIMV extremist and terrorist threats against soft targets, would work to enhance the multi-agency response. It would also help train staff and identify gaps or capability and protective security needs. This should be delivered locally – directly with soft target sites – regionally, and nationally to drive preparedness at every level. The importance of this cannot be overstated.



Conclusion

> “Threats are becoming increasingly complex, ‘driven by geopolitical tensions, accelerated by digital interconnectivity, and fuelled by ideologically diverse movements.’”

The 2025 EUROPOL Terrorism Situation and Trend Report noted how threats are becoming increasingly complex, “driven by geopolitical tensions, accelerated by digital interconnectivity, and fuelled by ideologically diverse movements.”[261] This is an age of complexity with “multiple overlapping threats on an unprecedented scale.”[262]

This report has considered how the landscape is evolving with a focus on the persistent and multifaceted security threats posed by NIMV extremism and terrorism combined. It has reviewed several case studies, analysed tactics and trends, and considered the need for a broader, proactive, and progressive approach towards Protect and Prepare. Notably, it highlighted that the prioritisation of accessible, yet enclosed, soft targets may be necessary.

More strategically, at a macro level, it was referenced how this threat picture becomes increasingly complex when the interplay with hostile state activities as well as proxy groups (such as Hezbollah/Hamas or criminal proxies conducting violent acts on behalf of states), is recognised.

Iran is widely known for harbouring terrorists whilst the Russian mercenary group, Wagner, was proscribed as a terrorist group by the UK Government.[263] The use of criminal proxies to commit an arson attack on a Ukrainian-owned business in east London on behalf of Russia is a recent case in point.[264]

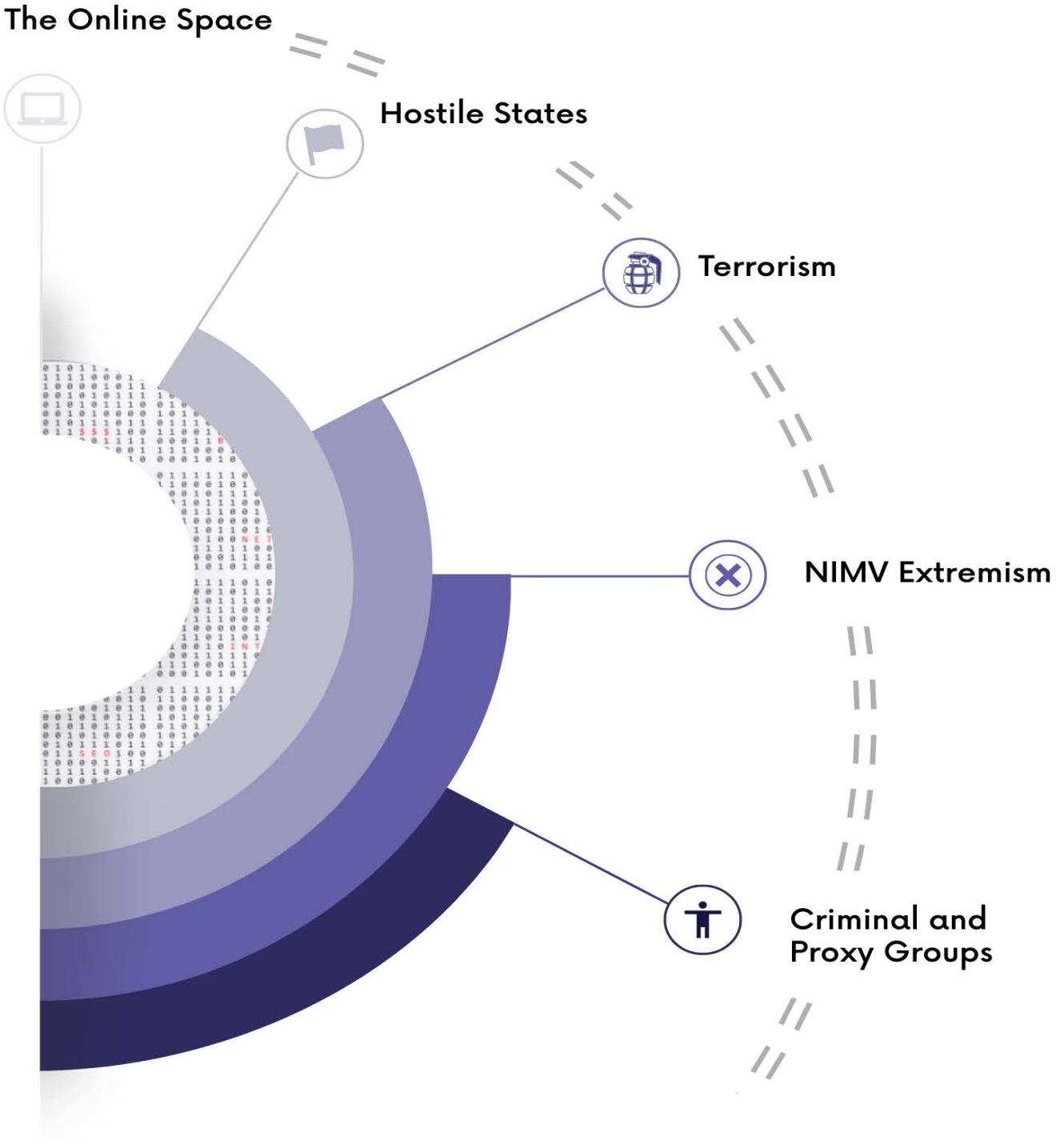
MI5 Director-General McCallum noted how arson, sabotage, and more are increasingly seen on UK streets, underscoring the need for the UK National Security Act.[265,266]

The wider layers of connectivity (flow of weapons and financing; movement of foreign fighters and agents; and the employment of crime-as-a-service) between hostile states, terrorism, and NIMV extremists are yet to be fully understood. But they are exacerbated and compounded by the online space, including the dark web. The following infographic simplifies this connectivity.

It reflects the fact that the national security threat is growing and broadening with hostile states becoming an increasing concern. It further illustrates how threats from terrorism persist alongside the growing challenge of NIVM extremists and proxy groups. It shows how it can be increasingly difficult to determine which actor is behind an incident/attack, and why it was perpetrated, whilst centering the online space as a core driver and connecting factor.

This requires detailed threat analyses; holistic threat mapping that seeks to distil the underpinning factors and layers of connectivity; and a strategic understanding that drives protection and preparedness.

Even nations and cities with robust arrangements remain vulnerable to hostile states and individuals motivated by ideology, grievance, or despair. There is an absolute need to commit to a broader and increasingly proactive approach in terms of how societies are protected, and how agencies prepare to respond to the threats faced.



A Blurred Threat Landscape

The expanding and interconnected web of state, terrorist, and extremist threats in the digital age.

Recommendations

Note: This is an international report designed for an international audience. It is recognised that arrangements and resources will vary, and it is accepted that different recommendations may or may not apply in different contexts. This list is non-exhaustive, and stakeholders are advised to consult the relevant lead agencies and specialist authorities whilst aligning with relevant local, national, and international policy.

1	Understand the differences and commonalities between NIMV and terrorist attacks, and what the legal, operational, societal, and communicative implications are.
2	Map the trends and trajectories of threats based on both NIMV extremist and terrorist attacks combined to inform Protect and Prepare strategies.
3	Consider threat drivers (such as misogyny and the weaponisation of gender), how these are countered, and what this means for organisational, city, and national policy or strategy.
4	Develop city-level strategies and initiatives with a focus on violence prevention and reduction.
5	Undertake a feasibility study to determine what can be done, when, and how, with a clear implementation pathway that offers measures for success against relevant strategies.
6	Apply best practice guidance from protective security authorities.
7	Explore innovative options for protective security that incorporate progressive approaches with behavioural sciences and technology as part of layered protective security models.
8	Build relevant plans, policies, procedures, and capabilities at single and multi-agency levels.

9	Ensure the establishment and ongoing enhancement of Fixed Threat Assessment Centres and Fusion Centres, also enabling connectivity with the relevant services (e.g., education).
10	Engage with Departments for Education and school services to progress safety and security. This also applies to the hospitality and event industry, and other potentially soft targets.
11	Utilise secure software and databases to store and enable access to security, emergency, and evacuation plans of different vulnerable targets by law enforcement agencies.
12	Deliver a locally led tabletop and live exercise programme focused on accessible but enclosed soft targets. This is with a view to informing enhanced security measures whilst serving as training for people and bolstering multi-agency response capabilities and plans.
13	Take a comprehensive approach to conduct targeted lockdown training, as appropriate.
14	Actively promote security awareness and conduct tailored training with private sector partners and staff, particularly those operating within soft targets. This should include clarification of responsibility and ownership relating to grey space.
15	Support innovative solutions that offer proportionate approaches by appropriate agencies to overcome encryption and lawfully intercept malicious communications, including online.
16	Advocate for progressive policy changes and restrictions; particularly in relation to enhancing online safety and security, countering the use of malicious platforms or materials, as well as strengthening checks and regulations against purchasing/owning potential weapons.

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